

Disorderly Retreat

The real battle, however, was yet to come. Nearly 40,000 NVA troops attacked the ARVN as they left the town, and the withdrawal quickly became a rout. Many ARVN troops lacked battlefield experience. In this test of Vietnamization, many fought well, but the army faced some overwhelming challenges. An orderly retreat under fire would have been a difficult maneuver even for veteran troops, and the ARVN forces lacked both the training and leadership needed to accomplish the task. The ARVN sustained heavy losses. It was only the bravery of US helicopter crews, going in despite poor weather and devastating anti-aircraft fire, that enabled the rescue of thousands of ARVN troops.

Lam's forces lost at least 5,000 men, killed or wounded, plus 2,500 missing in action. Some 700 US helicopters were destroyed or damaged beyond repair, and 253 US personnel lost their lives. Radio Hanoi termed the operation "the heaviest defeat ever for Nixon and Company." Traffic along that part of the Ho Chi Minh trail was only briefly stopped, and plans to expand the trail farther into Laos were underway.

This bleak reality, however, did not stop Nixon and Thieu from proclaiming a great victory for Vietnamization and for the ARVN. In April 1971, Nixon announced the withdrawal of another 100,000 US troops from Vietnam.



Help on its way

Four South Vietnamese rangers wounded during Lam Son 719 await medical evacuation to Phu Loc, a firebase near Khe Sanh and not far from the Laotian border. The NVA had attacked Phu Loc during the ARVN's advance in February, but it remained under South Vietnamese control.